

Interview : George Attla part 2

Story and images by Greg Sellentin



Portrait of George Attla by 17 year-old Fairbanks artist Shawna Zusi-Cobb.

We finished off in the last issue starting to talk about the dawning of the age of sponsorship in the growing sport and business of sled dog racing in Alaska. George was one of the first mushers to be seen as a “professional.”

GS: Did you have a set price for what it cost to be affiliated with George Attla the racer? Or did the sponsors come to you with offers?

GA: I had a set price. I had to make a living. Not only run my kennel, but I had a family, I had to support my kids too. I had a sponsor for every year I raced except the first year.

GS: Mushing can be a very all-encompassing and all-consuming sport. Sometimes mushers can lose their priorities. You see the sport responsible for relationship problems, job problems and the loss of those. I’m always amazed seeing mushers today that are able to juggle family responsibilities – 9 to 5 jobs, kids, etc. – and still run dogs competitively. Was that hard for you? How did you manage to keep it all together while being so dedicated to the sport and the dogs?

GA: Well when you are making a living mushing, supporting your family, the whole family is involved. If you don’t do that, I can see where things can go wrong.

GS: When you were racing full time, you traveled quite a bit. You went to the Tuffy’s Dog Food Triple Crown series in the Mid-West, the Alpo races in Saranac Lake, NY. What was your impression of racing in the lower 48?

GA: They all did a great job of putting on

dog races. I’d always be surprised at how professionally run these races were. Even the new races. They were very well run. The towns where the races were actually promoted the races and did a hell of a job.

GS: Did you ever race Laconia?

GA: No, I didn’t, I wanted to but the timing was wrong. It was too close to Rondy. The Pas also was a race I always wanted to do but couldn’t because the timing was wrong on that one too.

GS: With your perspective of over 50+ years of involvement, where do you see the sport of sprint sled dog racing moving to?

GA: I want to see the sport survive and go on. I don’t want to see it die a slow death. The only thing that can fix it is money. Even with young people, because they have to make a living too. Even back in the 1970’s I thought it was becoming a rich man’s sport.

GS: What do you think of today’s champions?

GA: Egil Ellis is a smart musher. I think he is focused on winning more ONAC and Rondy races than anyone. He doesn’t travel much, doesn’t do different types of racing, he stays within his area, and is just focused on beating those records. I think he wants to equal or do better than my record. In reality there is nobody living who can do that. Who today is going to do this sport for 40 or 50 years? A lot of the races I won are dead, they aren’t around anymore. You can’t equal that. Egil couldn’t do what he is doing if he didn’t love his dogs, but will he be doing it for 50 years?

GS: The kids in this day and age, have a lot of options for their free time. Back in the day, mushing may have seemed like a more attractive option.

GA: Back then, dog mushing was the biggest thing. Period. For instance, in this village, we had no gym, no place for kids to play, mushing was everything.

GS: Mushing is such a great way to teach kids life lessons. But more specifically, even as an adult, I’ve learned so much just specifically from working with my dogs. Each dog has personality traits, good and bad, that you can see the consequences of

almost immediately. Can you say if you’ve learned any big lessons from working directly with sled dogs?

GA: I don’t know if I learned anything, but my kids did for sure. Take a look at my kids today, 50 years after I started, and they are very dedicated adults. They commit themselves to something and stay with it. I did learn a lot about restraint. When working with dogs you can’t let your emotions get the best of you. For instance we just saw on the old film we were just watching, a guy kick at his dogs. You shouldn’t do that, you just don’t do that. You learn to control your emotions even when you are frustrated. I think it really did my kids good. They are completely different than some of the kids they grew up with. A lot of kids in the village would get sent to my place to work with me and the dogs. Those kids are different too. I used to leave the kids at my house when I was out of state. There was never a problem. The lesson I wanted to impart was confidence. You have to have confidence in what you are doing to be successful. Never for a minute should you doubt yourself. My mom and dad gave me that confidence. My dad was known as the best trapper in the state. He was a workaholic, even back then. He knew how to not only be the best trapper, knowing the game and the land intimately, but he knew how to grow the population of the same game he was trapping. I tell Fish and Game today, that my dad was a way better wildlife manager than you guys are today!

GS: Confidence is a funny thing, as opposed to over-confidence. I think confidence in yourself starts with applying yourself completely to accomplish an objective.

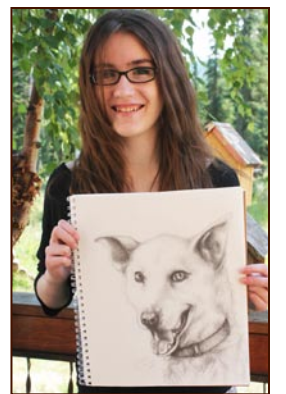
GA: Yes, and that transmits to your dogs. Even when you don’t do so well, you have to remember to praise your dogs. There is nothing wrong with getting beat, as long as you can honestly say to yourself that you gave it your best shot. As much as you prepare yourself to win, and set yourself up to win, you have to be prepared to lose. It’s life—you win some, you lose some it’s as simple as that. And the dogs always give it their best.

GS: Have you gone into any races, thinking you were under prepared?

GA: Never under prepared, but sometimes with not good enough quality dogs. You can’t make a winning dog out of a losing one, but you can always try. I always say that any great champion, no matter what you are doing, is the man that can take a beating without any problem. You have to be a good loser. I always had a reporter in my face with a microphone or camera after every race. Even though you just got your ass whipped, you had to watch what you say. There was a lot of pressure on me, although I didn’t really feel it while I was racing. I didn’t look at it that way. However, when I quit the sport, when I told my sponsors, I’m done, I don’t want to do this anymore, that was the biggest relief I ever had. I didn’t realize it, but there was a lot of pressure on me to win. As soon as I quit, the pressure was off. I didn’t have to win any more.

I did love the competition though. Even to the point where I would help my competitors. I told Charlie (Champaine) how to beat me. Harvey Drake, when he was learning, he would come to my house every night for a year. One day right before the North American, he said, “Are you ready to get your ass whipped?” I said, yeah, I’m ready to get my ass whipped. I beat him in that race, by a very close margin, and he never came back to the house. He is still mad at me today. Really strange.

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In addition to the portrait of George on the facing page, 17 year-old Fairbanks artist Shawna Zusi-Cobb also illustrated the portrait of Lingo that hangs in George’s home. We featured that portrait in part 1, but Shawna’s credit got cut off.

GS: Some competitors are more outspoken publicly. Like Eddy Streeper when he said you were washed up. Then you came back and won again.

GA: That was good for the sport. I liked it. He took a whipping, but I believed it did dog racing a lot of good. I laughed it off. What can you say? I didn't say anything. I didn't have to say anything. The papers wrote up their own stories.

GS: How friendly were you with your competitors? Like Doc Lombard, would you guys go out for dinner?

GA: We would stay at the same hotels, and train in the same spots. We weren't 100% friendly all the time. At least I wasn't. I liked to play head games. I was always trying to say things to get him mad at me, but he would never lose his temper. And Charlie Belford, he would get mad at me. He would scare me sometimes. He would get right in my face. I knew I could get to him. I watched people from other sports and how they could self-destruct. I learned from that. My favorite athlete was, and is, Muhammed Ali.

GS: Have there been times where you've been able to leverage your historic, celebrity status in Alaska to get things done, or for special causes?

GA: I used to do that a lot. Even today, especially in Northern Canada. It's amazing how well known I am over there. Because all the sprint races were televised, I became a sports figure. Now for the last 7 or 8 years, I've gone over there almost every year to speak.

GS: It would be nice to get the races covered in real time on TV again. It's amazing to me that it's not. I mean it is an exciting sport. I guess folks would rather watch some other supposed reality show. I mean, people are tuning in to watch dogs trot around a a show ring, or jump off docks into water. I think we have something more exciting than that. Now with helmet cams, and sled cams, the footage can be amazing. Imagine if we had that kind of footage when you were battling Doc Lombard.

GA: Back then, we didn't know who was going to win-Lombard or I. The TV coverage did a good job of covering it back then, and creating the drama. Things fell into place to be able to do that kind of production. Hopefully they will discover more oil, then there will be more money to be spent!

GS: Thanks for spending the time with me George, it has been an absolute pleasure.

GA: You're welcome. It was fun. •

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